

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The thesis accounts for 40% of the final module mark. The full mark of the thesis is 100 points.
2. The thesis must not exceed 10,000 words. A penalty of three points will be applied for every additional 100 words beyond the word limit. Refer to [Appendix I \(1. Length\)](#) for details on exclusions from the word count.
3. The thesis must be written in English, except for the abstract, which should be provided in both English and Chinese.
4. Only electronic submission is required. Each student must submit an electronic copy of the thesis via Learning Mall Online (LMO) by **17:00 on May 18, 2026**, China Standard Time (UTC/GMT+8).

Thesis Requirements

Each student will complete a research thesis following the suggested structure outlined below.

- Preliminaries
 - Coursework cover sheet (available on LMO)
 - Title Page (including the title of the project, student name and ID number, supervisor name, name of degree programme, date of submission)
 - Abstract, in both English (no more than 300 words) and Chinese
 - Acknowledgement (if applicable)
 - Table of contents
 - List of Tables (if any)
 - List of Figures (if any)
 - List of Abbreviations (if any)
- Main Body of Text
 1. Introduction/Background
 2. Literature Review
 3. Methodology
 4. Models/Results/Findings
 5. Discussion
 6. Conclusions and recommendations
- References
- Appendices

The structure provided above is intended as a general guideline. Given the diverse nature of projects, no formal structure is mandated. However, all thesis must include a **cover sheet** and **title page** (templates are available on LMO), along with an **abstract in both English and Chinese**, as well as an **introduction** and a **conclusion**. Supervisors may have different expectations regarding the appropriate structure. Therefore, students are advised to follow their supervisor's guidance when organizing their FYP thesis. For further details, refer to **Appendix I** for the FYP Thesis Format Guidelines and **Appendix II** for the suggested FYP Thesis Content by Section.

Appendix I: IBSS Final Year Project (BUS303) Thesis Format Guidelines 2025-2026 Academic Year

- Length:** The maximum length of the thesis is 10,000 words. The word count only includes the main body of text described above, i.e., it does not include:
 - Coursework Coversheet
 - Title Page and Table of Contents Page
 - Acknowledgement (if applicable)
 - List of tables, list of figures and list of abbreviations
 - Tables and Figures
 - Reference lists/Bibliography
 - Footnotes and Appendices - provided these have been used only when necessary. If footnotes or appendices are used excessively, or contain material that should clearly be included in the main body of the thesis, it is at the markers' discretion to include these in the word count.
- Coursework Cover Sheet:** A cover sheet must be included at the beginning of your thesis. The cover sheet should have the following format. The template is available on LMO module page.

XI'AN JIAOTONG-LIVERPOOL UNIVERSITY			
西 交 利 物 浦 大 学			
COURSEWORK SUBMISSION COVER SHEET			

Name	(Surname)	(Other Names)
Student Number		
Programme		
Module Title		
Module Code		
Assignment Title		
Submission Deadline		
Module Leader		

By uploading or submitting this coursework submission cover sheet, I certify the following:

- I have read and understood the definitions of collusion, copying, plagiarism, dishonest use of data, and academic offences involving Artificial Intelligence (AI) as outlined in the Academic Integrity Policy of Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University.
- This work is my own, original work produced specifically for this assignment. It does not misrepresent the work of another person or institution, nor does it present the work generated by AI as my own. Additionally, it is a submission that has not been previously published, or submitted to another module.
- This work is not the product of unauthorized collaboration between myself and others.
- This work is free of embellished or fabricated data.

I understand that collusion, copying, plagiarism, dishonest use of data, academic offences involving AI, and submitting procured work are serious academic misconduct. By uploading or submitting this cover sheet, I acknowledge that I am subject to disciplinary action if I am found to have committed such acts.

Signature Date

For Academic Office use:	Date Received	Working Days Late	Penalty ¹

¹ Please refer to clause 43 (i), (ii) and (iii) of the Code of Practice on Assessment for the standard system of penalties for the late submission of assessment work based on **working days**.

- 3. Title Page:** The thesis must have a title page with lettering of font Times New Roman size 16 in black. The title page should have the following format. The template is available on LMO.

Title of the Thesis By Student's Name Student ID number Supervisor: Name of supervisor A Thesis Submitted in Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements for the Name of the Degree to International Business School Suzhou Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University Date of Submission
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4. In order of Appearance:

- Coursework Coversheet
- Title Page
- Abstract
- Acknowledgment (optional)
- Table of Contents
- List of Tables (if any)
- List of Figures (if any)
- List of Abbreviations (if any)
- Main Body of Text
- References/Bibliography
- Appendices (if any)

- 5. Abstract:** Each thesis must be accompanied by an abstract and a list of keywords. The abstract should be written in both English (no longer than 300 words) and Chinese.

6. Table of Contents: The table of contents must show chapter headings and page numbers. All separate sections of the thesis, such as abstract, bibliography, lists of abbreviations, appendices, etc., must also be identified on the contents page.

7. Headings: Chapters or major sections should be clearly numbered. Subsections should be numbered 1.1 (then 1.1.1, 1.1.2, ...), 1.2, etc. No more than three (3) levels of headings can be used. Each heading should be left-aligned and appear on its own separate line. Headings of chapters or major sections are in boldface, font size 14 and title case. Sub-headings appear like major headings, except they are in font size 12. Sub-sub-headings appear like sub-headings, except they are in italics and not boldface. See the example below:

1. Chapter/Section Heading

1.1. Subsection Heading

1.1.1. Sub-subsection Heading

8. Paragraph: Except for the first paragraph under a heading, indent each new paragraph by 1 cm. After a quotation or equation, when the text is the continuation of the text preceding the quotation or equation, the first line must be flush left; otherwise indent.

9. Font: The main body of the thesis should be typed in letter quality using Times New Roman font size 12 and 1.5 line spacing. Long quotations (quotes of more than two full lines) should be indented by 1cm from each margin, single-spaced and in block quotations. No quotation marks should be used.

10. Paper Size and Margin: A4 size paper should be used as the word processing template, with 1 inch (2.54 cm) in top, bottom, left and right margins.

11. Page Number: Page number should be in **Arabic** numerals and runs consecutively throughout the body of the thesis. This also includes pages containing Bibliography, and Appendices. For the preliminaries (preface, acknowledgements, table of contents, list of tables, list of figures, etc.), page number should be in Roman lower-case numerals.

12. Footnote: Footnotes should be inserted at the foot of the relevant page in single line spacing. Smaller type may be used, if available. A line should be ruled between footnotes and the text. Footnotes should be numbered consecutively throughout the thesis. The reference number for the footnote in the body of the text is a superscript numeral, not enclosed in parentheses.

13. Figures and Tables:

- Figures and tables should be numbered consecutively and appear immediately following the text as the first point of reference.
- Each table or figure is to be identified with the word “Table” or “Figure” and its number. All figures and tables should be referred with their numbers in the main text where appropriate.
- Tables and maps should have titles or captions at the top and figures should have titles or captions at the bottom.
- A list of all tables and a separate list of all figures, identifying each by name, number, and page must be included in the preliminaries (prefatory pages).

- Avoid using any screenshots to present original results in the assessment. Inappropriate snapshots may lead to certain marks deduction.

14. Reference and Citation: The bibliography or references to published work should be given consistently in the style of Harvard or APA Referencing System and be cited properly in the main text. The detail guide and examples of reference can be found from the XJTLU library (<http://libguides.lib.xjtlu.edu.cn/xjtlureferencing>).

Appendix II: Suggestions for FYP Thesis Content by Section

Section/Chapter	Contains
Title Page	Title of the research project, student ID, Name, Department details
Abstract	Can be either structured or a single paragraph but should be no more than 300 words long. The Abstract should summarise the key findings of the research and 'sell' the research project to potential readers. Think about how you use the abstracts of previously published work and consider how your abstract can do the same for your work.
Acknowledgements	This is a chance to thank all the people who have helped you with the work, or provided important feedback (e.g., your supervisor). Where you have studied companies or organisations you would normally take the chance here to thank the person who made that access possible. It should also include a statement that the work is your own.
Table of Contents	This will be on the second page of the project and should guide the reader to the various sections. Contents pages should not receive numbers such that the introduction appears on page 1. Normal convention favours numbering multiple contents pages with roman numerals e.g. I, ii, iii, iv, etc.
Introduction	Since this is the first section the reader will look at, it is very important that the introduction sells the rest of the thesis. Use the first section to explain why the research topic, and the research question in particular, should be of interest to the reader. Typically, this will include impressive facts about the context or the backdrop against which the project is set. Take the opportunity to explain who should be interested in the research (e.g., policy-makers, firms or maybe both)? It is also useful to explain why you have chosen this topic for your FYP. Most importantly, you need to state your overarching research aims and objectives here. Secondly, set out the way in which you will address the research problem with a section that explains what is to come (i.e., provides an overview/summary of the thesis structure). This will then signpost the reader to the parts they are most interested in reading.
Literature Review	One of the key skills of the FYP is the ability to read and analyse academic literature, and to demonstrate your understanding of this literature. The second of the main sections is the place to do this. You should include in your review (i) those academic papers that set the scene for your own study, (ii) those papers that employ similar techniques but are applied to different contexts to your own research, and (iii) papers on your research context but that use different techniques. If there has been past research with similar techniques in a similar context to yours then these should also be included in your review. It is essential that you can demonstrate to the reader what makes your project unique (i.e., you should try to identify what is already known and what is less well known), and you need to show how your research addresses this knowledge gap. In particular, where there are similar studies to your own FYP topic you must explain why and how your study differs (e.g., in your findings) and is more relevant. From the literature review you should be able to show that the methods you are using, and the research question you are addressing, are interesting and relevant. Ideally, the research questions you are trying to answer with the FYP should derive from your literature review. Thus, it is good practice to state in this section your research questions, or hypotheses, or propositions you are trying to find answers to.

Section/Chapter	Contains
Methodology	The way in which you approach your research and answer your research questions is very important. This section offers you the chance to explain what data collection and analysis techniques you have used and why. Better projects will evaluate the methods and explain any weaknesses (or limitations) in them. Where possible you should also explain how you have overcome the weaknesses you identify, or how their presence should be considered in the conclusions (i.e., how they affect the interpretation of your findings).
Models/Results / Findings	Where you are using a particular statistical model, it is common to explain the model and the way in which it is estimated or applied. In theoretical modelling the key assumptions and ideas are a vital step before you can present any results. Some projects will not have models and so will skip straight from the method to the results or findings section. All FYPs, however, will have some findings that should be explained in this section. Your aim is to introduce and present the findings (i.e., analysis, evaluation and discussion come later), although some commentary will set the best projects apart from a simple statement of results. Presentation of the results themselves is also important, so think about what sorts of tables, graphs and charts will best convey what you have found to the reader.
Discussion	Here you draw together the literature review, past studies and your own work, to determine what common themes exist. Equally, look for things that differ and try to sell your results in the context of those previous studies you have reviewed that found results to the contrary. Throughout the discussion, you should be linking back to the issues you identified with your methodology and to the research questions that were raised in your review of the literature. Most importantly, you should clearly identify how well you

	have achieved your stated research aims and objectives. In this section you should explicitly state what answers you have found to your research questions, hypotheses or propositions.
Conclusions	Bring together in the concluding section the outcomes of your evaluation and express them in a clear and concise way for the reader. Explain how you got there and assess what could have been done differently to strengthen your work. It is normal here to have some criticism of your own work, but remember you are still selling the importance of your project. It is normal to end this section with a discussion of what research could naturally follow yours, and what you would do if you had more time. For some projects, a statement of recommendations for policy- makers and/or managers arising from the research findings should be included here.
References	A list of references should be supplied in alphabetical order at the end of the FYP.
Appendices	You do not have to have appendices, and these will not be formally assessed in the project marking. However, where you have interviews or survey studies, you are expected to provide transcripts of those interviews or the original questionnaire as an appendix. Similarly, if you have large volumes of data that could be used to support the analysis you make in the main document then including that data in an appendix can be a clever move. Do not simply put things in the appendix for the sake of it, however, because they do make the final document 'heavy' and

	could put the reader off. Discuss the inclusion of any appendices with your supervisor.
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